

Photographs by PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

PEOPLE'S LEADER Rajasthan CM Bhajan Lal Sharma with beneficiaries of the Ujjwala Yojana LPG connection scheme, at his residence in Jaipur in December last year

A political life has a way of bringing a measure to things. If not in a starkly spartan way, Bhajan Lal Sharma retains that good country feel to his daily rhythms: up at sunrise, a brief stroll in the sprawling lawns where the two cows he keeps are always indulged with a spot of patrician patting, and then a busy day interspersed with simple, home-cooked vegetarian meals. A calendar bustling with meetings means he often ends up skipping—or delaying—his early dinner. His demeanour, though, is not devoid of rosy reminders of his carefree, younger days when he was fond of eating—he even won a bet once by consuming over two dozen laddoos at a wedding feast without any water in between. In December 2023, no one would have grudged him a few extra sweets when his name was called out, tambola-style, in the game of chance that decided Rajasthan's chief ministership. He was nowhere in the race: a first-time legislator, he was being pitchforked from near-anonymity to high office. But from that moment of elation, it didn't take long to appreciate how much of a "double-edged sword" politics can be, as Sharma confesses ruefully to INDIA TODAY.

The agony came when the BJP lost 11 of the state's 25 seats in the general election. Sharma can't mask the hurt still, but offers no excuses. Aides say his body language for days after June 4 suggested he took it as a personal failure. Even if he had no say in candidate selection or campaign design, he felt he had let down the party that had elevated him to a much-sought-after office. Clearly, life would have been simpler when he was just a humble apparatchik back in Bharatpur district, where being sarpanch of his village, Atari, was the last administrative office he had held.

Despite stints as state unit vice-president and general secretary, he was a faceless surprise when fielded from Sanganer, the block-printing capital in the shadow zone of Jaipur, for the assembly poll. Even then, he wouldn't have dreamt of a coronation in the city of rajas. But at these stratospheric heights, peril lay at every step. Despite his stoic silence, his facial expressions reveal a sense of betrayal at the hands of Rajasthan's saffron pantheon—there's no dearth of leaders who would have hoped to succeed him in case the electoral shock led him early to the exit door.

But Sharma recovered his poise in no time. Primarily because the party brass stood firmly behind him: it had disappointed at least six heavyweights in handpicking him and, after gambling so big, it was not going to pull out its stakes so soon. Indeed, despite the seeming gap, the BJP's Lok Sabha win-loss map almost aligned with its geographical vote spread in the assembly polls. That December victory hadn't been the sort of bumper harvest it gets in, say, Gujarat or Madhya Pradesh. So instead of saddling Sharma with the onus, the party removed C.P. Joshi from the post of state president—it was under his captaincy that the BJP fought both assembly and parliamentary elections, so the line of ownership was clearer. The new state unit chief, Madan Rathore, is another low-profile leader—not one known to be bristling with ambition. The high command clearly does not wish to create another power centre.

THE LONG-TERM BET?

Sharma has clearly been given more time to understand administration and deliver. Of his eight months as CM, three were anyway lost to the model code of conduct. Besides, a good part of his cabinet too has the appearance of having benefited from a kind of political apprenticeship scheme and needs time to learn on the job—most ministers are novices, still prone to fumbling while answering questions in the assembly. Now it's squarely up to Sharma to dispel the notion that the high command had erred in choosing a newcomer like him, in a field where his own side may be as eager as the Opposition to show him up as a wrong choice. That keeps him under an uncomfortably constant spotlight, with no room for mistakes and keenly watched not just for what he delivers but for how long he lasts.

In short, people's expectations are tuned to *small*—they imagine Sharma's policy horizons to be limited by his mofussil past. No one is even anticipating anything by way of vision. But within the system, there's beginning to be a grudging acknowledgement that the opposite may be truer. Ideationally, the new CM is not devoid of the grand